

statistics favoured Zverev: a 39-1 record against players ranked outside the Top 10 at the French Open since 2018, and a 92 per cent service hold rate in five matches going into the semifinals.

A rock-solid opening 7-5 set ignited Zverev's comprehensive 7-5, 6-2, 3-6, 6-3 victory. With former Czech champion Jan Kodes, tennis great Agassi and basketball star Kawhi Leonard watching, Mensik sparked hope for an upset only when he broke serve with a forehand drop-shot winner for 4-2 in the third set. But Zverev quickly got back in the driver's seat with a break for 2-0 in the fourth set. Zverev was efficient, clinical and relentless, with no hint of nerves.

Champion at last

For the first time, Zverev was favoured in a Major final. Germany was also yearning for its first Grand Slam champion since national hero Boris Becker won the 1996 Australian Open and its first French Open winner since Henner Henkel in 1937. Cobolli also had history on his mind. "It's a dream of my career, of my life," he said. In attendance was Adriano Panatta, a dashing, long-haired serve-and-volleyer and the last Italian champion here in 1976.

The nervous Cobolli looked overwhelmed by the occasion, losing his serve three times in the opening 6-1 set. The momentum shifted abruptly in the fluctuating seventh game of the second set. Zverev, who said he spends more practice time on his second serve than any other part of his game, double-faulted twice. Spectators chanted for Cobolli as he eventually secured the critical break for 4-3 and soon claimed the set, 6-4.

Zverev's last six losses have all been to Italians — four to Sinner — but he regrouped in the pivotal third set. After smacking a backhand winner to hold for 4-4, Sascha, who has Type 1 diabetes, gave himself an insulin shot during the changeover to control his blood sugar level.

When Cobolli fired a rocket forehand winner to hold for 4-all,



spectators sang in appreciation. Zverev broke serve to take the set 6-4 on an overhit Cobolli forehand error and pumped his fist and raised his arms to elicit more love from the crowd. The pendulum swung again in the fourth set, which climaxed in a tiebreak, something Zverev hadn't lost at Roland Garros in four years. The energised Cobolli took a 6-4 lead with a gutsy forehand drop-shot winner from the backhand alley à la Nadal, only to blow the next point, set point, when he mistimed an easy overhead. He redeemed himself with a clutch forehand winner to seize the 7-5 tiebreak and the fourth set.

Order was restored in the lopsided deciding set. Zverev

Rising stars: Jakub Mensik was one of the young guns who impressed the most. **Below:** Moise Kouame, the youngest player in the draw at 17, beat the likes of Marin Cilic on his way to the third round. AFP & REUTERS

dictated with his bludgeoning serve and heavy groundstrokes, earning three service breaks against the weary Cobolli. Sascha also showed true grit, fending off three break points and conjuring a backhand volley winner on game point to take an insurmountable 4-0 lead. When Cobolli overhit a smash on championship point, a relieved and ecstatic Zverev fell on his back in celebration.

